MODULE 08 · AMBITIOUS ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Finding First Users

Who are your first ten customers — by name?

COURSE PATH



COURSE MATERIAL · SCAN NOW

All slides live on GitHub

The newest version, free, no account needed

github.com/BaNburger/
AmbitiousEntrepreneurship

1. **Open the link**
   github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship
2. **Go to modules**
   then 08-first-users
3. **Click the lecture PDF**
   M08_Lecture_Finding-First-Users.pdf, download top right

Public course repository of Ambitious Entrepreneurship. The QR code opens github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship.

WHERE WE ARE · THE COURSE

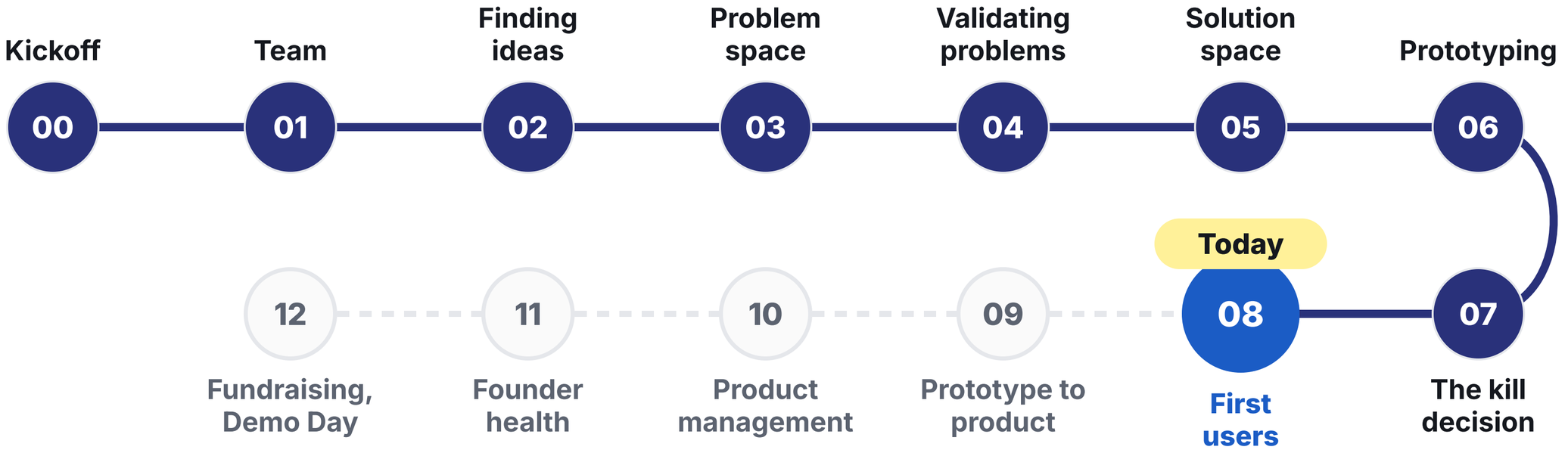
From a verdict to the first euro

Thirteen sessions from first idea to first revenue. What teams have by now:

A live MVP people used
Prototyping (M06)

A verdict: Go, Pivot or Kill
The kill decision (M07)

An offer with a price and names
The kill decision (M07)



CHECK-IN · SHOW OF HANDS

Go, Pivot or Kill. Did your line confirm it?

Go | **Pivot** | **Kill**

2:00

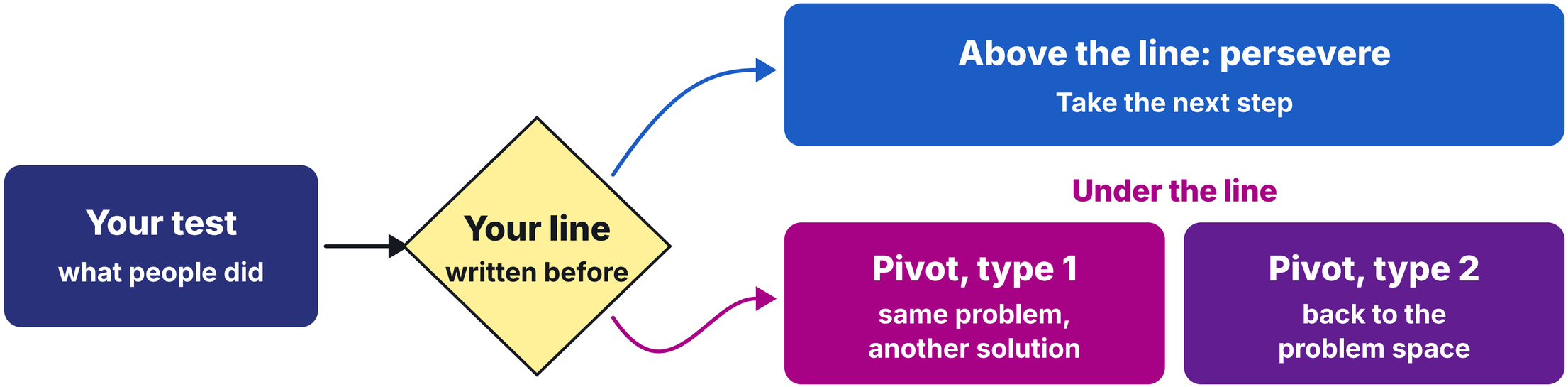
Confirmed or changed against your line?

And the offer and price you sell from today

PIVOT OR PERSEVERE

Under your line? That is a decision, not a failure

Every verdict is progress, and every verdict sells today



Both are progress. The only miss: no line, so no decision

FRAMEWORK Pivot or persevere after Ries, E. (2011), The Lean Startup. Pivot types as in the course Glossary.

ACCOUNTABILITY

Three questions, every session

1

User interactions?

What did you learn?

2

New revenue?

Why did they pay?

3

Shipped?

Why does it matter?

🦄 **Report target vs. actual in small groups**

CHAPTER 1 OF 9

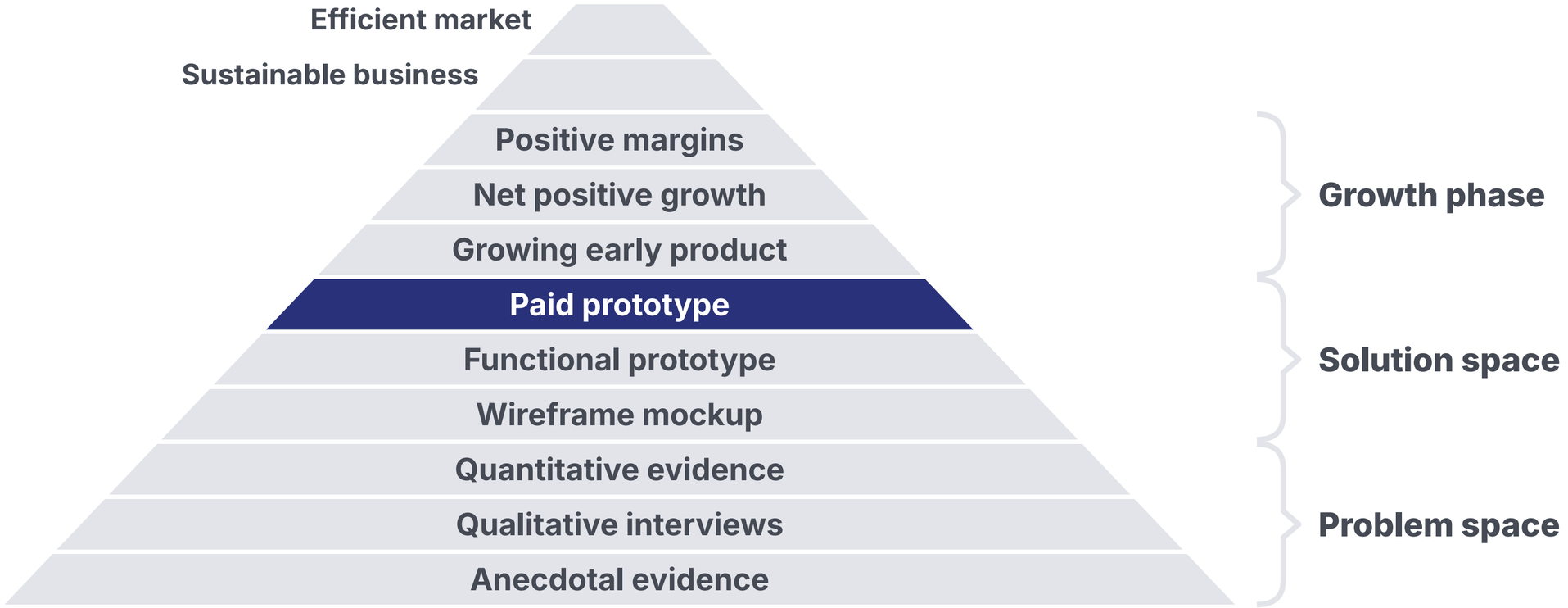
Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship

Four pictures from earlier sessions that you need to follow today.

01 **Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship**
02 Your presentations
03 **Do it by hand: things that don't scale**
04 **Sell it: like a founder**
05 **Count it: make the numbers go brrr**
06 **Charge for it: ask for money today**
07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 Workshop: Sell by hand
09 Case discussion

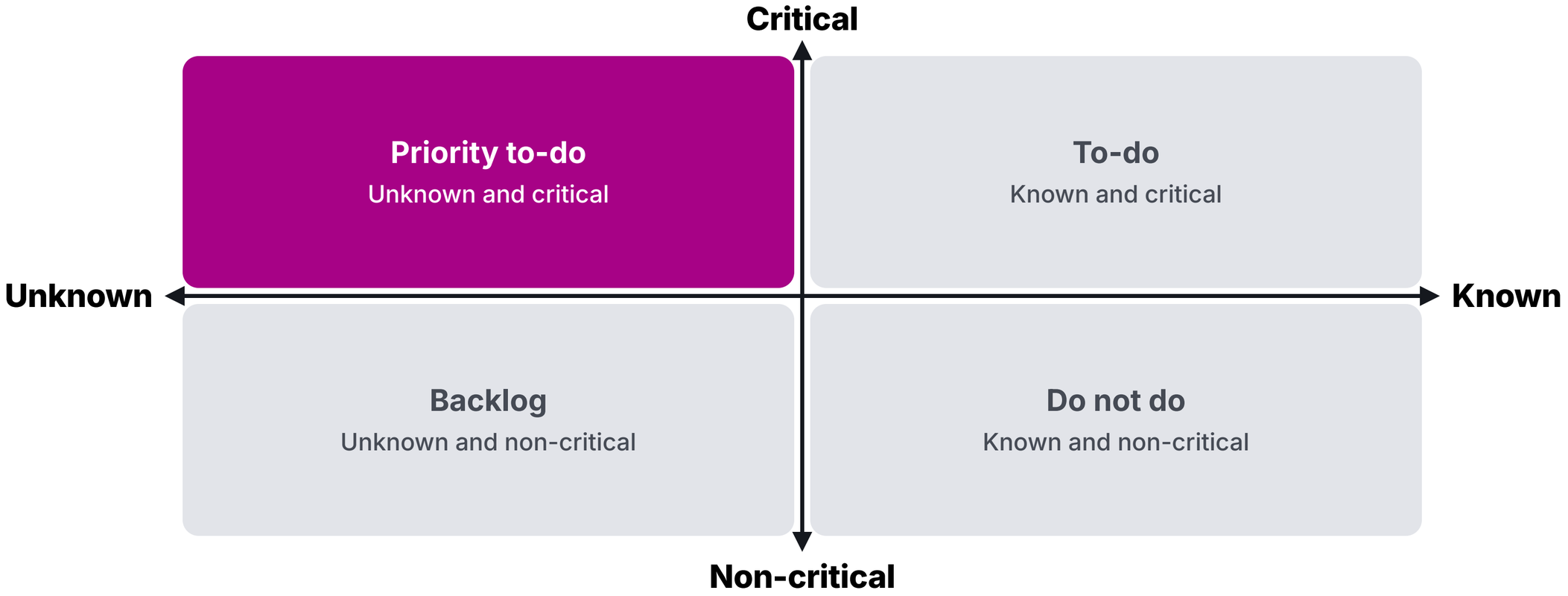
PREVIOUSLY · THE KILL DECISION (M07) · RUNG SIX

You tested at the wallet line



PREVIOUSLY · THE KILL DECISION (M07)

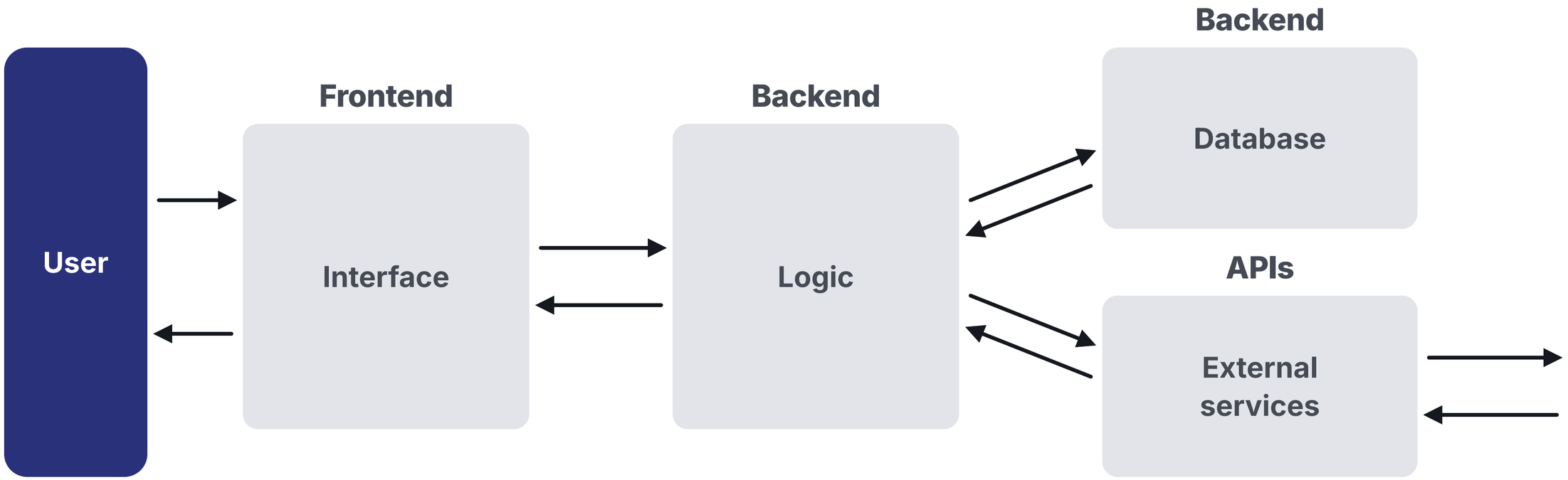
Your monkey was the unknown that could kill you



PREVIOUSLY · PROTOTYPING (M06)

Your MVP is live. Now it needs customers

The user box still needs one who pays



PREVIOUSLY · PROTOTYPING (M06)

Four questions before every build

1. Does your solution match the problem?
2. For whom is it 10x better than what they have now?
3. How can you build this in 4 hours?
4. **How can you get it in the hand of your customers?**

TODAY'S QUESTION · QUESTION 4

How can you get it in the hand of your customers?

1:00

CHAPTER 2 OF 9

Your presentations

Each team confirms its verdict and names the offer and price it sells today.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 **Your presentations**
03 **Do it by hand: things that don't scale**
04 **Sell it: like a founder**
05 **Count it: make the numbers go brrr**
06 **Charge for it: ask for money today**
07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 Workshop: Sell by hand
09 Case discussion

YOUR PRESENTATIONS · MAKE IT CREDIBLE

Show us where you're at in 3 minutes or less!

3:00

Facts

The monkey

In one sentence

Why it was the critical unknown

12 Numbers

Your Toolkit

People tested per student

The line next to its result

Scorecard total, weakest section

Quotes

The test

Two, with roles, not names

Images

The offer

Offer with its price

Kill Ritual page, if anything died

Verdict: confirmed or changed against the line, and a pivot's type

What did you do?

What did you learn?

How can we help?

Do it by hand: things that don't scale

Get each first user by hand, set it up on the spot, deliver what's missing.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~

02 ~~Your presentations~~

03 **Do it by hand: things that don't scale**

04 **Sell it: like a founder**

05 **Count it: make the numbers go brrr**

06 **Charge for it: ask for money today**

07 Wrap-up and check-out

08 Workshop: Sell by hand

09 Case discussion

INPUT 1 OF 4 · DO IT BY HAND · THREE QUESTIONS

Where do your first ten come from?

1

Where do your first ten customers come from?

2

What do you do on the call?

3

And if you killed your idea?

The most common unscalable thing founders have to do at the start is to recruit users manually.

Paul Graham, co-founder of Y Combinator

ESSAY

Do Things That Don't Scale

Paul Graham, July 2013

DO THINGS THAT DON'T SCALE

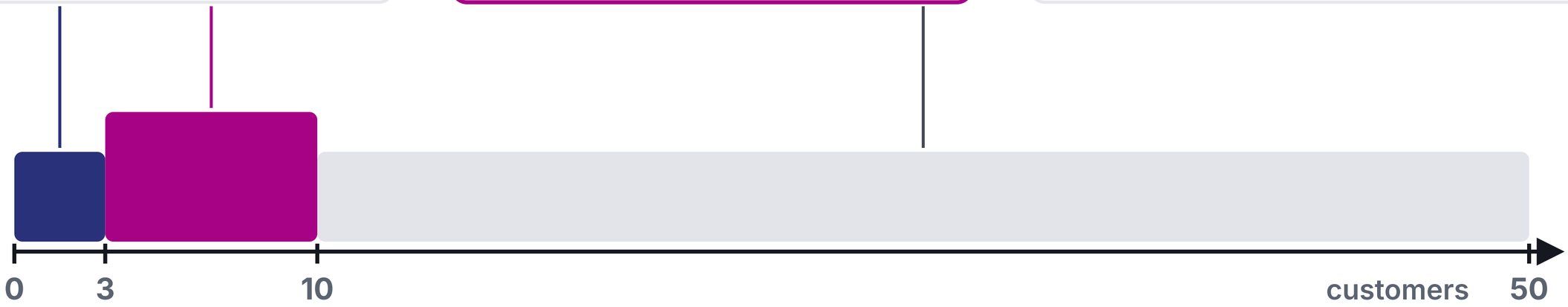
Your first ten customers won't come from a tool

Founders get their first ten by hand, one person at a time

1 to 3
People one introduction away

4 to 10
Things that don't scale

10 to 50
Tools like Apollo and Clay



YC Kolysh (2026), How to get your first 10 customers, Y Combinator. Drawn to the customer count.

DO THINGS THAT DON'T SCALE

Skip the sign-up link. Set it up while they watch

A yes without use is a yes you lose

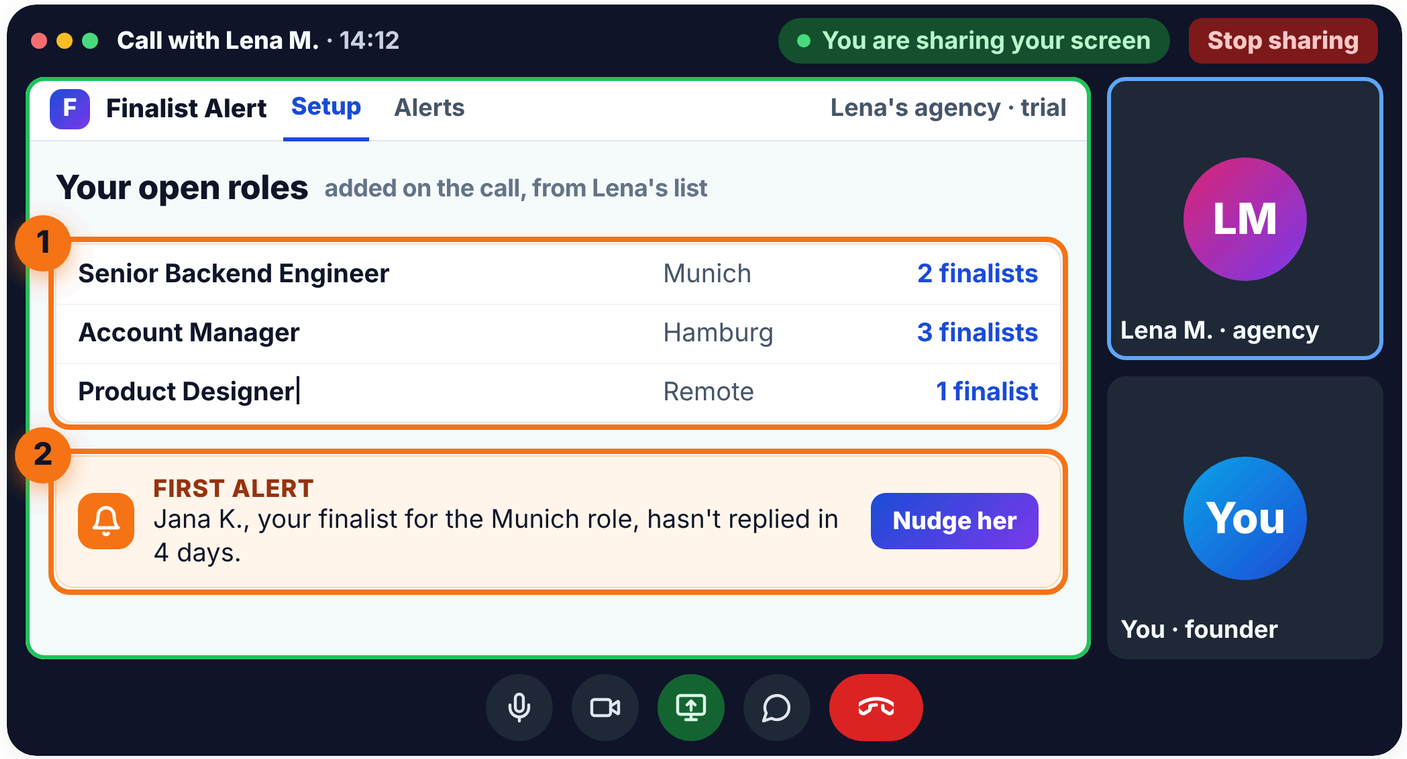
"Great, I'll send you the sign-up link"

Their inbox → "Later, maybe" → Gone

"Got five minutes? Let's set it up now"

1. Their own data in
2. First outcome on screen

→ **Used today**



YC After Graham (2013), Do things that don't scale. Paths made up. Call and product screen prototyped for this course, Illustrative.

MAKE NUMBERS GO BRRR · CUSTOMERS

Be their concierge. It's real revenue

IMPRESSIONS

- Always be posting
- Improve your targeting
- Improve your relevance

Tool
Posting & outreach

CLICKS

- Farm your friends & family
- Guide through keynotes & presentations

Tool
Keep the flywheel going

SIGN-UPS

- Demos, interviews, ...
- Personal interaction

Tool
Interviewing techniques

CUSTOMERS

- Show attention
- Manage your funnel
- Be their concierge

Tool
Managing your funnel

WORKED EXAMPLE · MADE UP

Set up on the call, delivered by hand

Finalist Alert's first customer, step by step

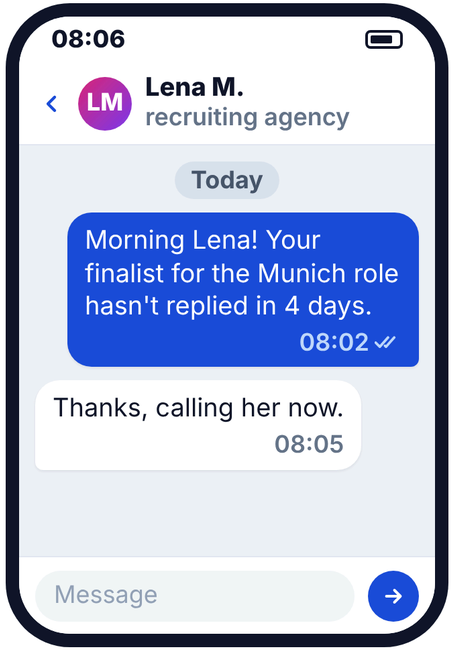
On the call

Her three open roles go into the sheet while she watches

That evening

A founder checks the finalists' replies, by hand

Next morning



WhatsApp, sent by hand

€49 a month

ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture of the course, "Finalist Alert". Messenger screen prototyped for this course, real apps look different.

RESTART AFTER A KILL

Killed it? You still sell today

1. Read what seven weeks produced
2. Pick the strongest asset
3. **Make a concierge offer, with a price**
4. Name the people

A concierge offer counts like any other offer

NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

What will you do by hand from today?

Set up — What you set up on the call

By hand — What you do that the product can't

Price — What it costs them

2:00

OUTPUT

Three lines in your notes

INPUT 1 OF 4 · DO IT BY HAND · THE ANSWERS

Do it by hand: set it up while they watch

1

Where do your first ten customers come from?

Not from a tool. Founders get them by hand, one by one

2

What do you do on the call?

Skip the sign-up link. Set it up while they watch, be their concierge

3

And if you killed your idea?

You still sell today, starting from what your weeks produced

INPUT 2 OF 4 · CHAPTER 4 OF 9

Sell it: like a founder

Switch from learning to selling, ask the right people, and never drop a thread.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Do it by hand: things that don't scale~~
04 **Sell it: like a founder**
05 **Count it: make the numbers go brrr**
06 **Charge for it: ask for money today**
07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 Workshop: Sell by hand
09 Case discussion

INPUT 2 OF 4 · SELL IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Who sells your first customers?

1

When do you switch from learning to selling?

2

Whom do you ask?

3

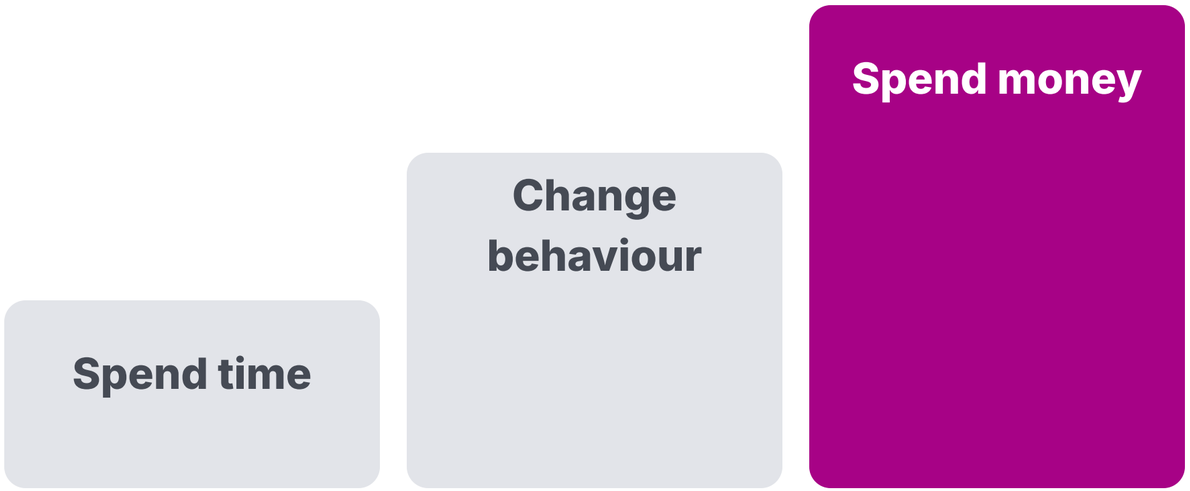
What happens after the first message?

SELL LIKE A FOUNDER

You're in luck. You're not selling used cars!

As a founder, you are the first salesperson

Sales = structured conversations that turn interest into commitment



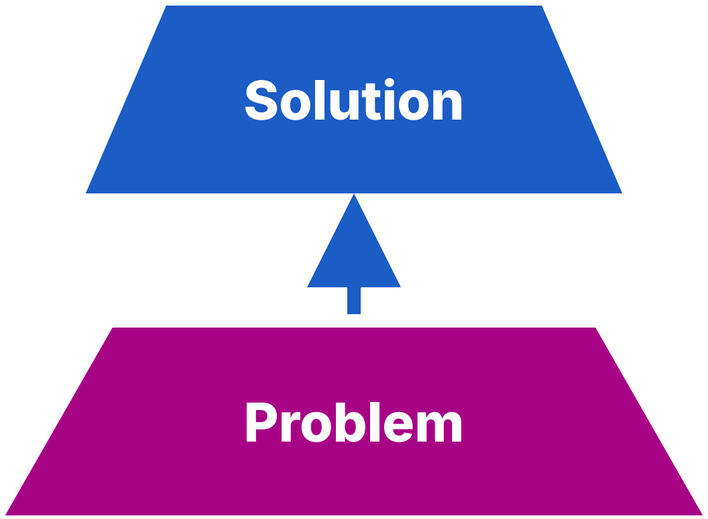
Kolysh (2026): the founder doing it personally is the advantage.

FROM DISCOVERY TO SALES

When the pattern repeats, start selling

Still 80% listening, 20% demo

Customer discovery
"I want to understand your problem and context"
Learning, not pitching



Sales conversation
"I think we can help, here's how"
Match their problem with your offer, ask for one next step

WHOM TO ASK

Ask people who pass all four

The Pain Map from Problem space (M03) already names who holds the budget

They like your value proposition

Every lecture ever

They have money

They can say yes to paying

Your first customers

They are hungry

They feel the pain right now

They are around

You can reach and serve them

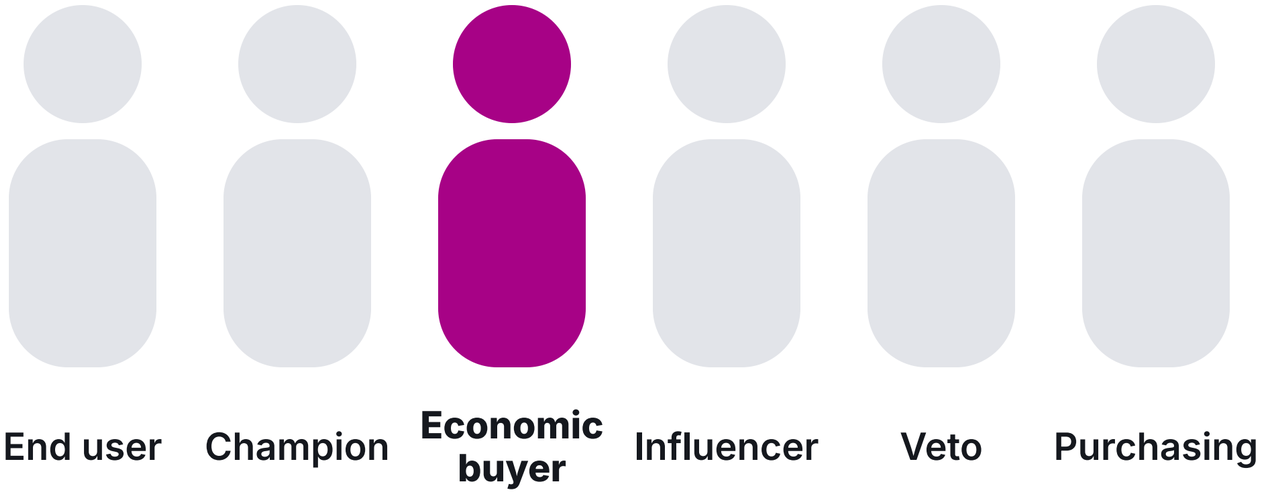
+ what else?

Depends on what you offer

WHOM TO ASK · B2B

In B2B, more than one person decides

Find the user, the champion and who pays



Ask your champion: "Who else has to say yes?"

WHOM TO ASK · B2B

Ask someone who can sign your price

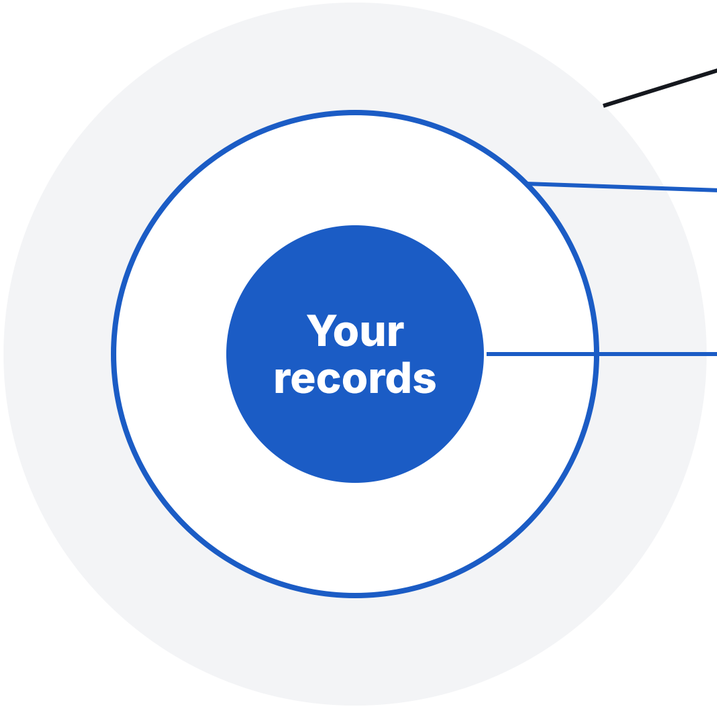
Signing limits at one large German corporate

TITLE	CAN SIGN UP TO	WHAT CONVINCES THEM
CEO	€10 million	10-year vision, P&L impact
CXO	€1 million	P&L impact, competitive advantage
SVP or VP	€500,000	Revenue gains, cost efficiency
Director	€100,000	Cost efficiency in €
Head	€50,000	Product benefit
Manager	€1,000	Product benefit

WHOM TO ASK

Friends open doors. Strangers pay

Start in your records, then one introduction away



Where your segment gathers · groups, events, forums

One introduction away · ask every buyer and every no for names

Your records · the ten from The kill decision (M07), first buyers, the Use Log, sign-ups, interviewees

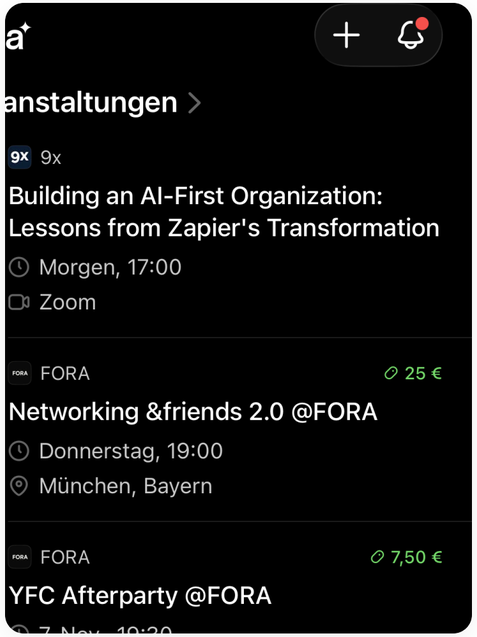
Friends, family, classmates
Ask them for introductions, not for money

WHOM TO ASK · RE-SHOWN FROM VALIDATING PROBLEMS (M04)

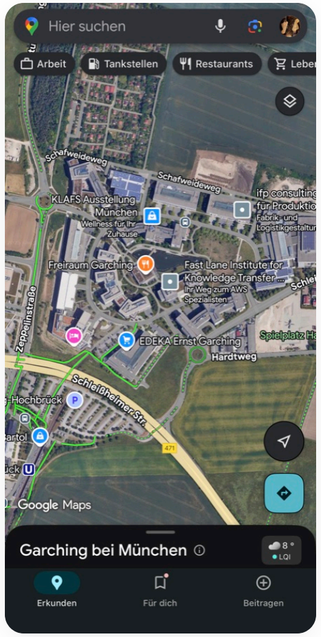
Name the room, not the channel

Go where they already complain in public

ONLINE COMMUNITIES · ONE NAMED EVENT



OFFLINE PLACES · A CANTEEN



Phone screenshots, Bastian, 2025. Kolysh (2026): find the place where the pain is expressed in public.

NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

Name the first three you'll ask

Open Your Interview Log and Use Log

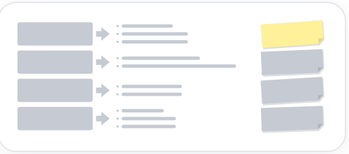
Filter Three who pass all four

Note Where each one came from

2:00

OUTPUT

Three names



OUTREACH · 1 OF 2

Write in their words. Ask for one next step

Under 75 words. Read it out loud first

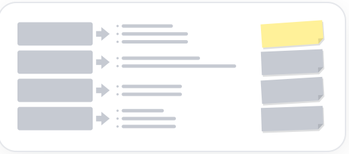
L **Lena · agency recruiter · message**

Hi Lena, in March you said "I lose a finalist every month and find out too late." (1) We now flag that by WhatsApp, **€49 a month** (2). **Can I set it up with you Thursday at 10:30? 15 minutes.** (3)

~~Hi! We're building an AI platform that revolutionises recruiting. Check out our website. Would you be interested?~~

1. **Their words**
2. **Your price**
3. **One next step**

YC Kolysh (2026): under 75 words, one clear call to action, read it out loud. Mom Test cheatsheet, framework 01: seek commitment and advancement. Message made up.



OUTREACH · 2 OF 2

Give first, then ask

Never come empty-handed

Email · "Two minutes, five warning signs"

Hi Lena, we interviewed 14 recruiters about finalists who drop out. Here are the five warning signs they named. (1) If you like, I'll watch your current finalists for them. **Thursday 10:30?** (2)

ATTACHMENT · ONE PAGE

5 warning signs before a finalist drops out

What 14 recruiters told us

(1) **The gift, before the ask**

(2) **Then one next step**

YC Kolysh (2026): the highest-converting outreach gave something before asking. Course material, "Give first, take second" and "Never come empty handed". Email made up.

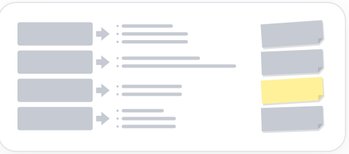


CHECK BEFORE YOU SEND

As a rule of thumb, 1 high-quality lead is worth about

10–50 low-quality leads

Passes all four? Their words? One next step?



THE CALL

Prepare five minutes. Listen for the rest

Then ask for one next step

First 5 minutes
Prepared, not improvised

Goal of the call
Your walk-away (BATNA)
"Is this a good time to speak?"

They talk, you listen
About 80% of the time

Listening to reply
~~Evaluate~~ · ~~Probe~~
~~Advise~~ · ~~Interpret~~

Listening to understand
Mimic · Rephrase
Reflect

The ask
One next step

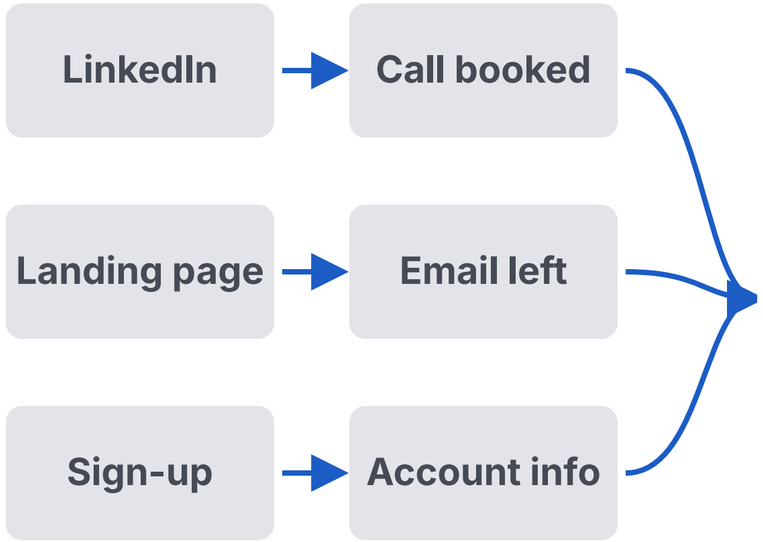
Rephrase their pain, then ask for the next step

RESEARCH Weger et al. (2014), 115 people: active listening made them feel more understood than advice. Covey (1989), habit 5. Fisher and Ury (1981), BATNA. Antoine's tricks, Bastian's course material.

SELL LIKE A FOUNDER

Never, never drop the thread!

Follow up three or four times, until yes or no



PIPELINE · STUDENT TOOLKIT · MADE UP

Person (name)	Channel	Touches (dates)	Next follow-up	Reply	Offer and price asked	Answer	Paid on
Recruiter, Berlin	Demo user	Mon		yes	€49 a month	paid	Wed
Lena, agency	**Demo user**	**Mon, Thu**	**next Mon**	**yes**	**€49 a month**	**later**	
HR lead, 40 staff	Introduction	Tue	next Fri	none			
Recruiter, Hamburg	Meetup	Mon, Wed		no	€49 a month	no	

Pipeline sheet, Student Toolkit. Kolysh (2026): follow up three or four times over a couple of weeks.

INPUT 2 OF 4 · SELL IT · THE ANSWERS

Sell it: you are the first salesperson

1

When do you switch from learning to selling?

When the pattern repeats. Still 80% listening, 20% demo

2

Whom do you ask?

People who pass all four checks and can sign your price. Strangers pay

3

What happens after the first message?

You follow up three or four times, until yes or no

INPUT 3 OF 4 · CHAPTER 5 OF 9

Count it: make the numbers go brrr

Count every step from stranger to activated user, then double down on what works.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Do it by hand: things that don't scale~~
04 ~~Sell it: like a founder~~
05 **Count it: make the numbers go brrr**
06 **Charge for it: ask for money today**
07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 Workshop: Sell by hand
09 Case discussion

INPUT 3 OF 4 · COUNT IT · THREE QUESTIONS

What do you count?

1

What do you count?

2

How do you push each stage?

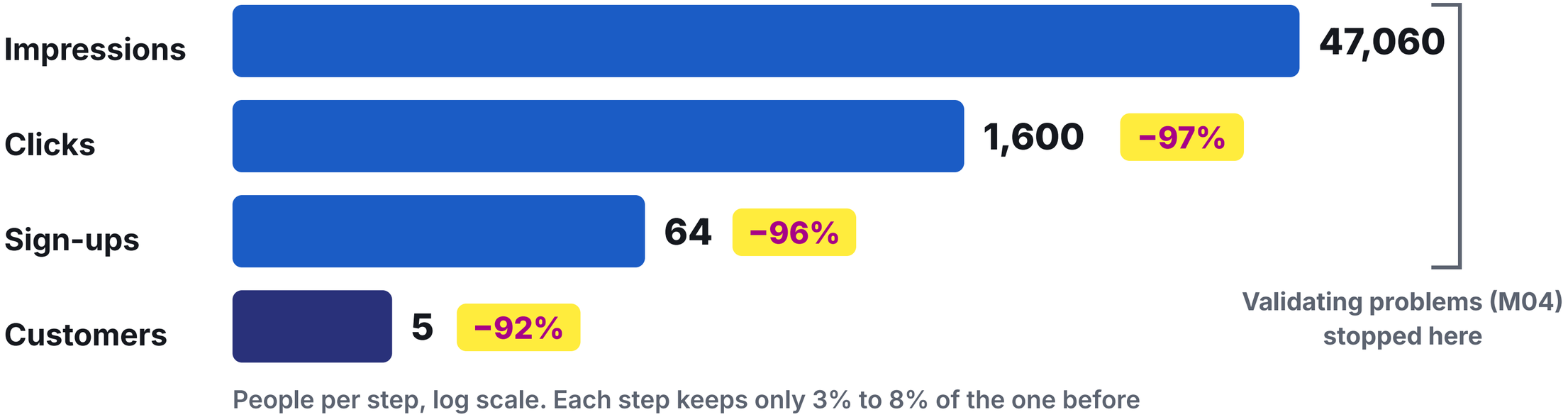
3

When do you double down?

MAKE NUMBERS GO BRRR

Every step loses most of the people

Bastian's example, 47,060 impressions to 5 customers



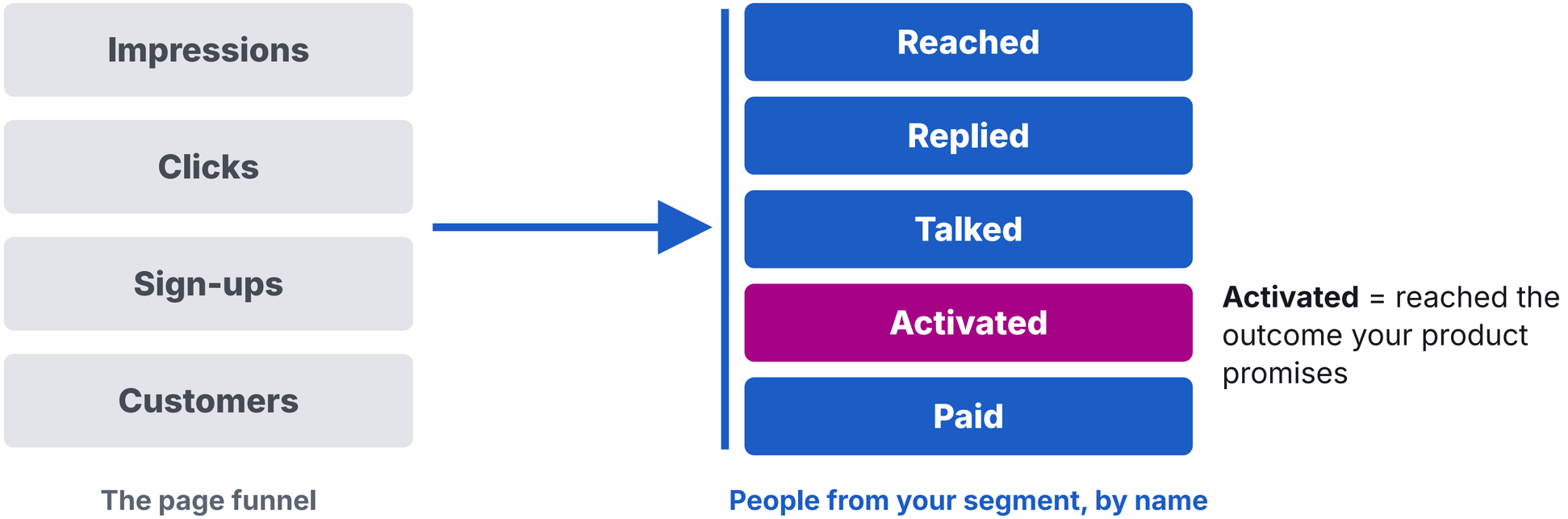
On each conversion, you lose about 1–2 orders of magnitude

Unbounce (2024): SaaS landing pages convert a median 3.8% of visitors.

MAKE NUMBERS GO BRRR

Count people, not page views

Reached, replied, talked, activated, paid



MAKE NUMBERS GO BRRR · TODAY'S SESSION ON ONE PAGE

Push every stage with its own tool

IMPRESSIONS

- Always be posting
- Improve your targeting
- Improve your relevance

Tool
Posting & outreach

CLICKS

- Farm your friends & family
- Guide through keynotes & presentations

Tool
Keep the flywheel going

SIGN-UPS

- Demos, interviews, ...
- Personal interaction

Tool
Interviewing techniques

CUSTOMERS

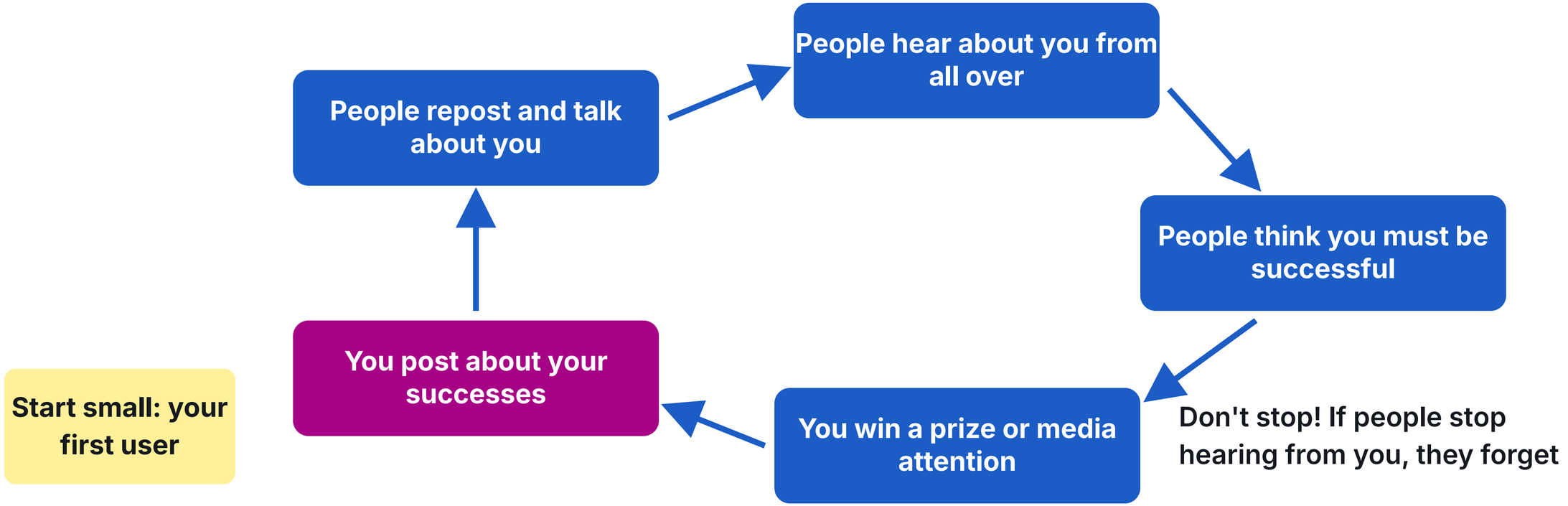
- Show attention
- Manage your funnel
- Be their concierge

Tool
Managing your funnel

MAKE NUMBERS GO BRRR

Start the flywheel and keep it going!

When you need the attention, it's way too late to start





WORKED EXAMPLE · MADE UP

Count every step, per channel

Finalist Alert's first week, four channels

Channel · people per step	Reached	Replied	Talked	Activated	Paid
Earlier demo users	10	8	7	5	3
Introductions	8	6	5	3	1
Cold LinkedIn	40	4	2	1	0
Recruiter meetup	6	6	4	1	0

−90%

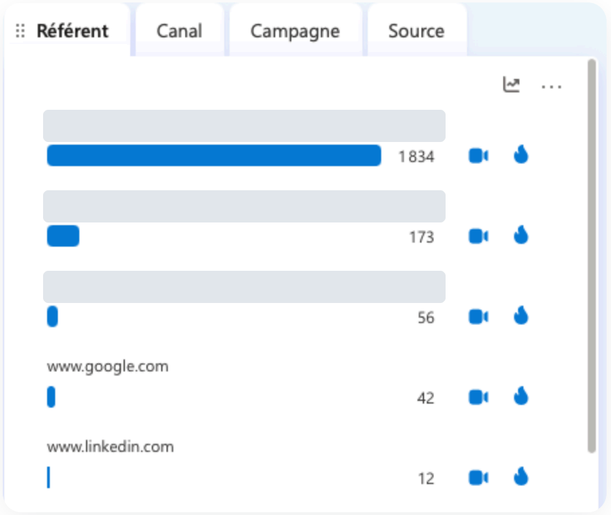
ILLUSTRATIVE Made-up recruiting venture of the course, "Finalist Alert". Bars to scale, 0 to 40 people. Counted in the Pipeline sheet.

MAKE NUMBERS GO BRRR

Double down where activated users come from

2x the input. More than 2x the outcome?

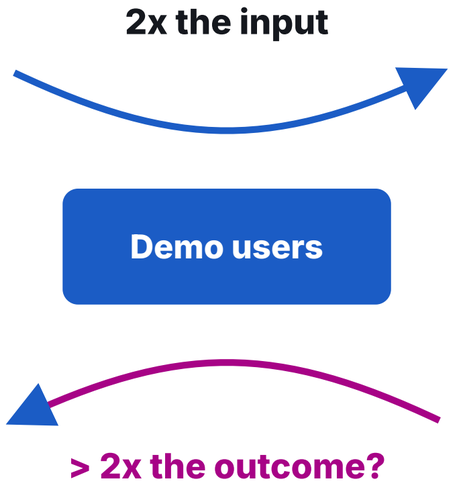
WHERE VISITS COME FROM



ACTIVATED USERS PER CHANNEL · MADE UP

Demo users	5 Here
Introductions	3
Cold LinkedIn	1
Recruiter meetup	1

THEN MEASURE AGAIN

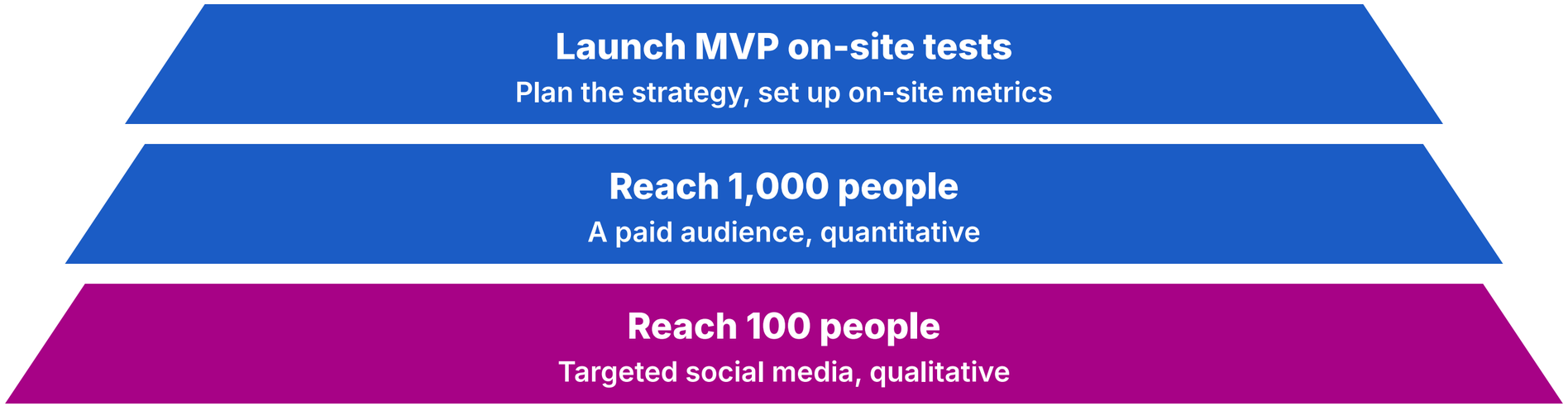


Microsoft Clarity screenshot on Bastian's screen, undated, page visits per referrer as set up in Validating problems (M04), branded and project names covered. Logos are trademarks of their owners. Activated users from the worked example of Finalist Alert, made up.

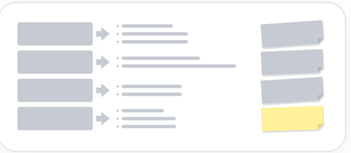
MAKE NUMBERS GO BRRR

Once a channel works, reach 100 people through it

Then 1,000, then tests on your own site



Below them: team, friends, loose contacts and strangers, the earlier rungs



NOW YOU · PAIRS · 2 MINUTES

Where do most of your people drop?

2:00

INPUT 3 OF 4 · COUNT IT · THE ANSWERS

Count it: people, per step, per channel

1

What do you count?

People, not page views: reached, replied, talked, activated, paid

2

How do you push each stage?

Each stage with its own tool. Start the flywheel before you need it

3

When do you double down?

Where your activated users come from. Then reach 100 people through it

INPUT 4 OF 4 · CHAPTER 6 OF 9

Charge for it: ask for money today

Ask at your offer's price, take the payment on the spot, log every objection.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Do it by hand: things that don't scale~~
04 ~~Sell it: like a founder~~
05 ~~Count it: make the numbers go brrr~~
06 **Charge for it: ask for money today**
07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 Workshop: Sell by hand
09 Case discussion

INPUT 4 OF 4 · CHARGE FOR IT · THREE QUESTIONS

When do you ask for money?

1

Why ask for money now?

2

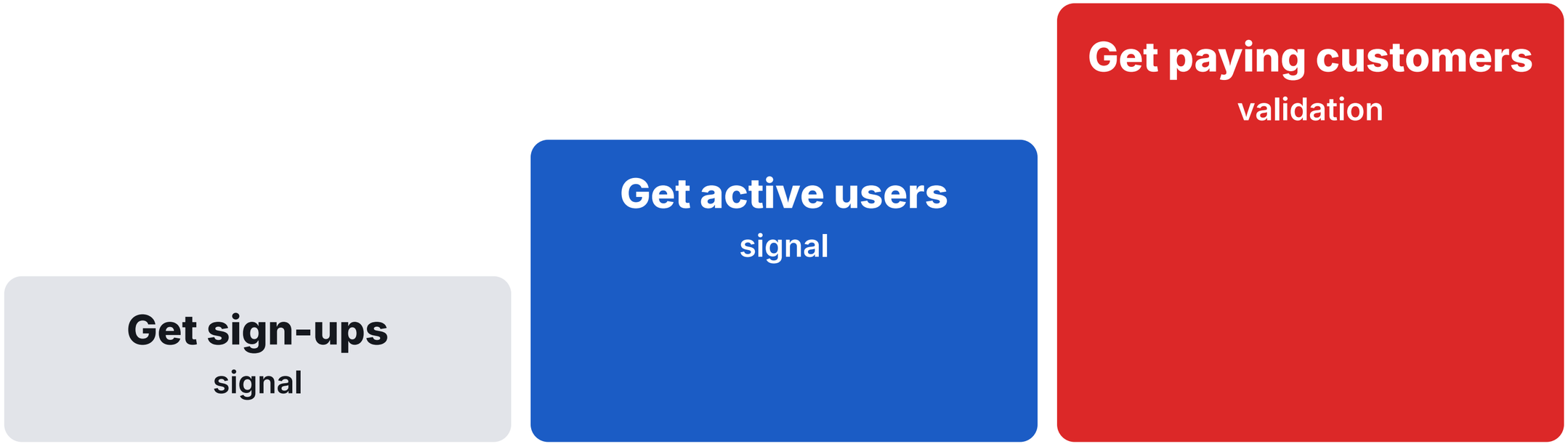
How do you ask?

3

What counts as a payment?

MANTRA · RE-SHOWN FROM VALIDATING PROBLEMS (M04)

Real validation comes through the credit card

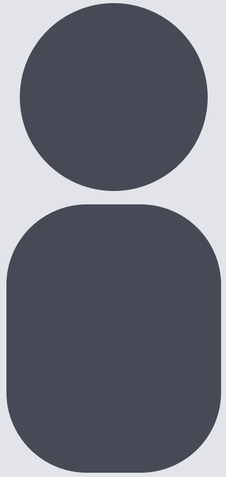




ASK FOR MONEY TODAY

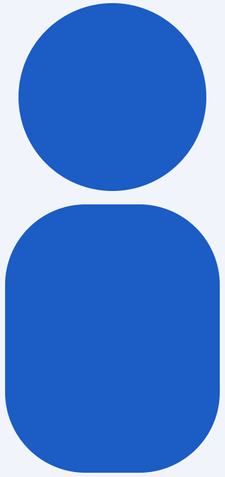
Customers pay. Everyone else is a fan

Fans are lovely and pay no rent





Fan
Likes it, signs up, says "love it"



€49 paid

Customer
Their money is on your account



ASK FOR MONEY TODAY · RESEARCH

"I'd pay for that" is not a payment

Stated values ran a median 1.35 times real ones



Stated value as a multiple of the real payment, real = 1.00.
Median of 28 studies, 83 comparisons. Many far above it.

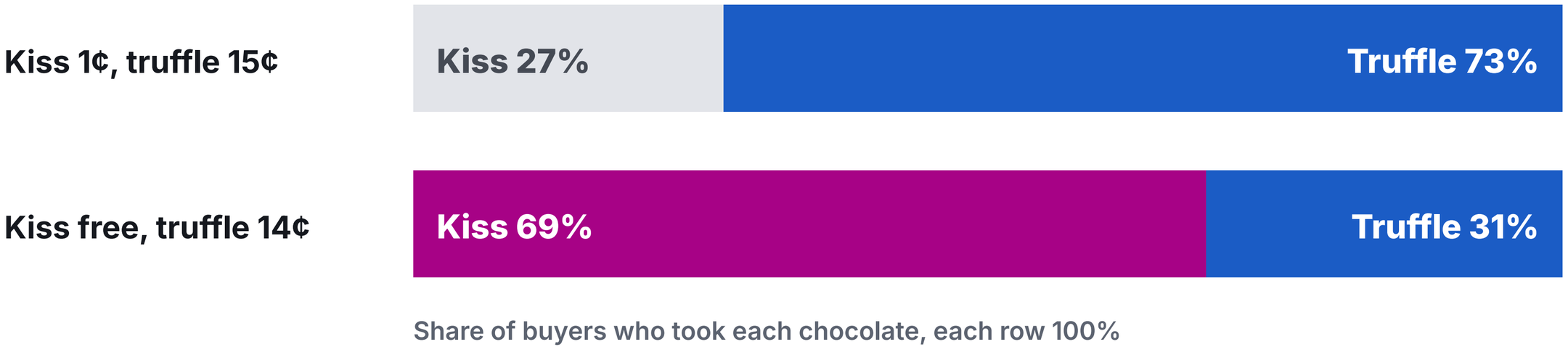
"I'd pay $X for that." Hypothetical money isn't real. Ask for a pre-order.



ASK FOR MONEY TODAY · RESEARCH

Zero is a special price

One cent less, and the choices flipped



Share of buyers who took each chocolate, each row 100%

RESEARCH Shampanier, Mazar and Ariely (2007), experiment 2: real purchases, 398 people, shares of those who took a chocolate.



THE ASK

Ask today, at your offer's price

Name the price, send the link, stay quiet

This would really help us.

It's **€49 a month**. I can set it up now and send you the payment link while we talk. Shall we?

... and then stop talking

NOT AN ASK

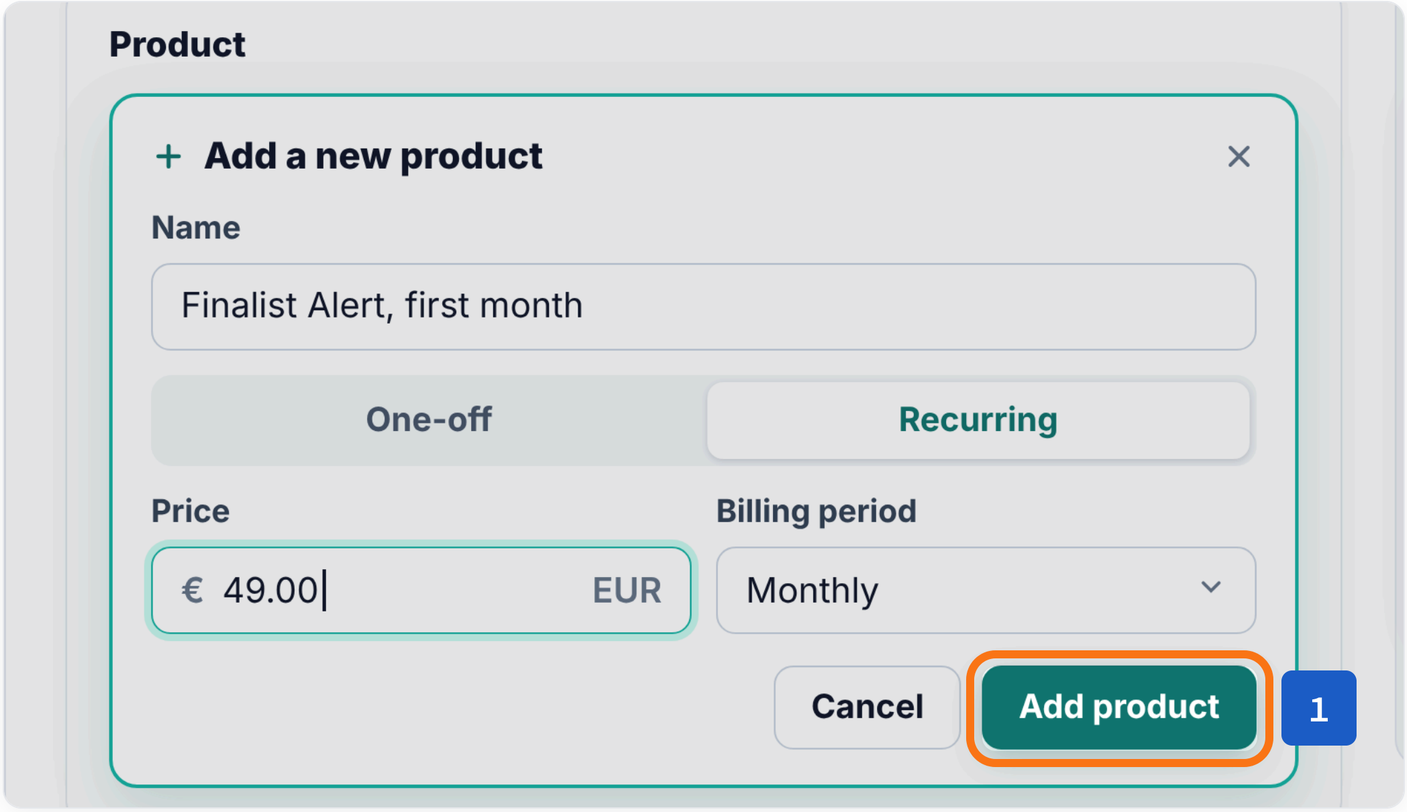
~~"Would you pay for something like this?"~~

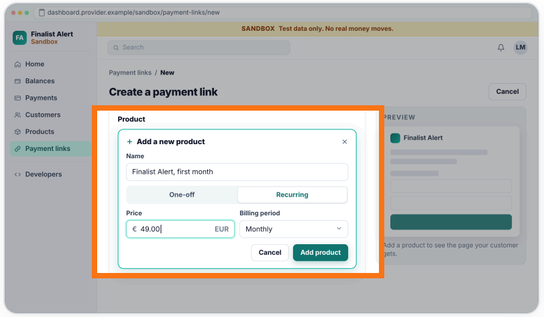
~~"We launch soon. Can I add you to the list?"~~

First users (M08) homework, move 5, ask at your price. Team Stack, section 2: send the link while on the call. Antoine's tricks: after closing, shut up. Call made up.

LIVE DEMO · STRIPE PAYMENT LINK · SANDBOX

Step 1: Create the product and its price





1. **Create the product and its price**
2. Create the link
3. Send it while you're still talking
4. See the payment arrive

Sandbox first. No real money moves.

ILLUSTRATIVE A payment provider's sandbox, prototyped for this course. Stripe's real screens look different. Steps and button names after docs.stripe.com/payment-links, accessed 2026-10-20, product made up.

LIVE DEMO · STRIPE PAYMENT LINK · SANDBOX

Step 2: Create the link

Product

Finalist Alert, first month
€49.00 / month · Recurring

✓ Selected

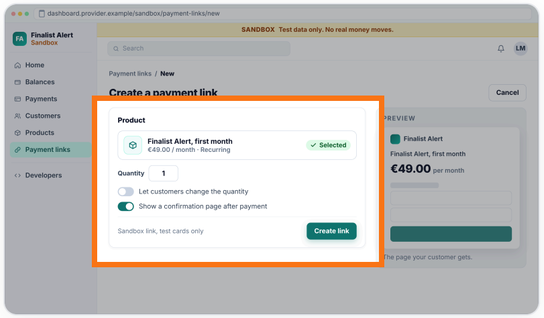
Quantity 1

Let customers change the quantity

Show a confirmation page after payment

Sandbox link, test cards only

2 **Create link**



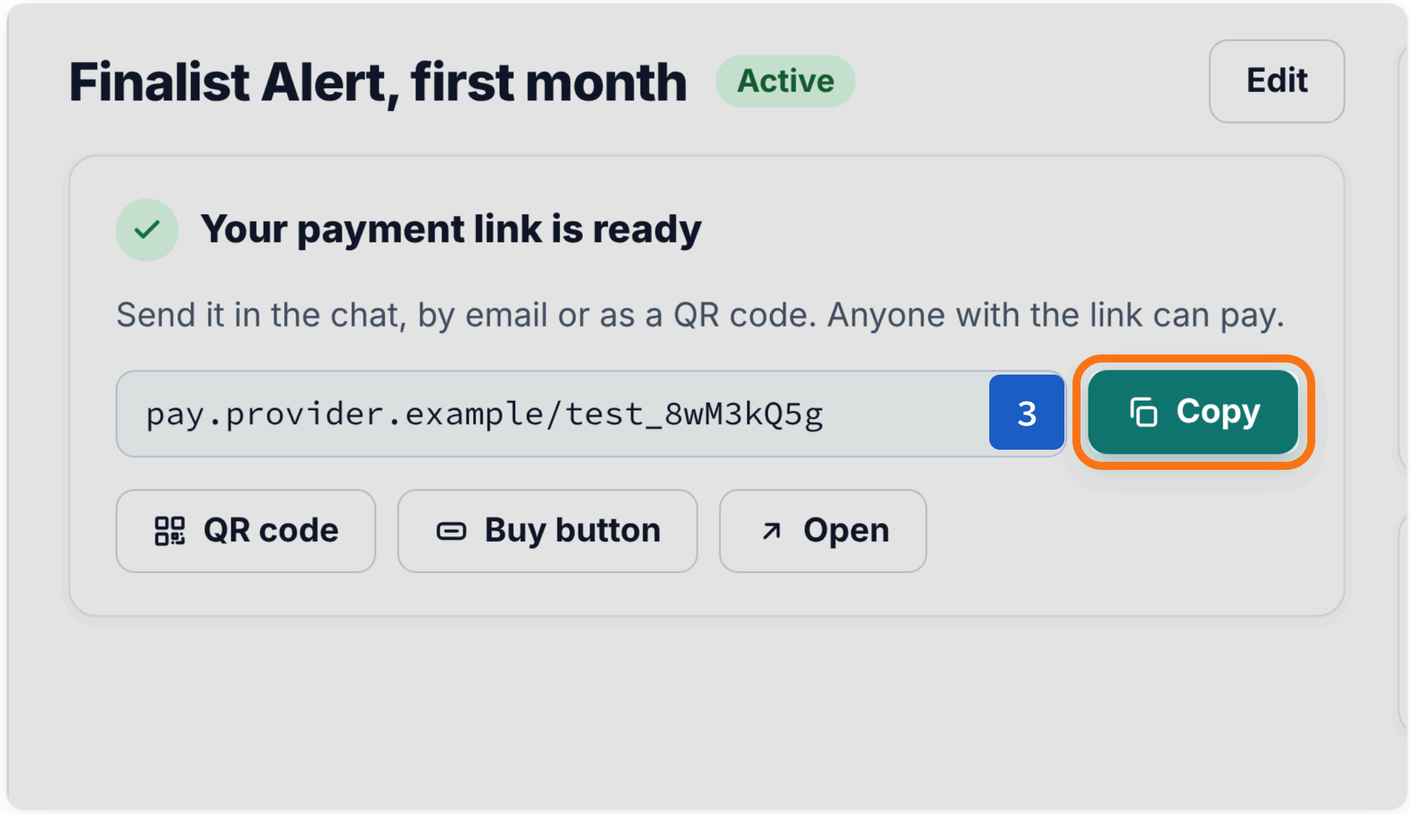
1. Create the product and its price
2. **Create the link**
3. Send it while you're still talking
4. See the payment arrive

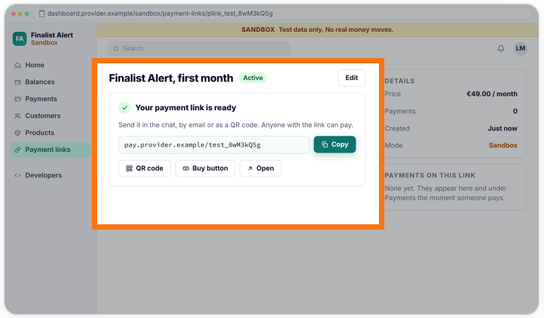
One shared team account, never a private one.

ILLUSTRATIVE A payment provider's sandbox, prototyped for this course. Stripe's real screens look different. Steps and button names after docs.stripe.com/payment-links, accessed 2026-10-20, product made up.

LIVE DEMO · STRIPE PAYMENT LINK · SANDBOX

Step 3: Send it while you're still talking





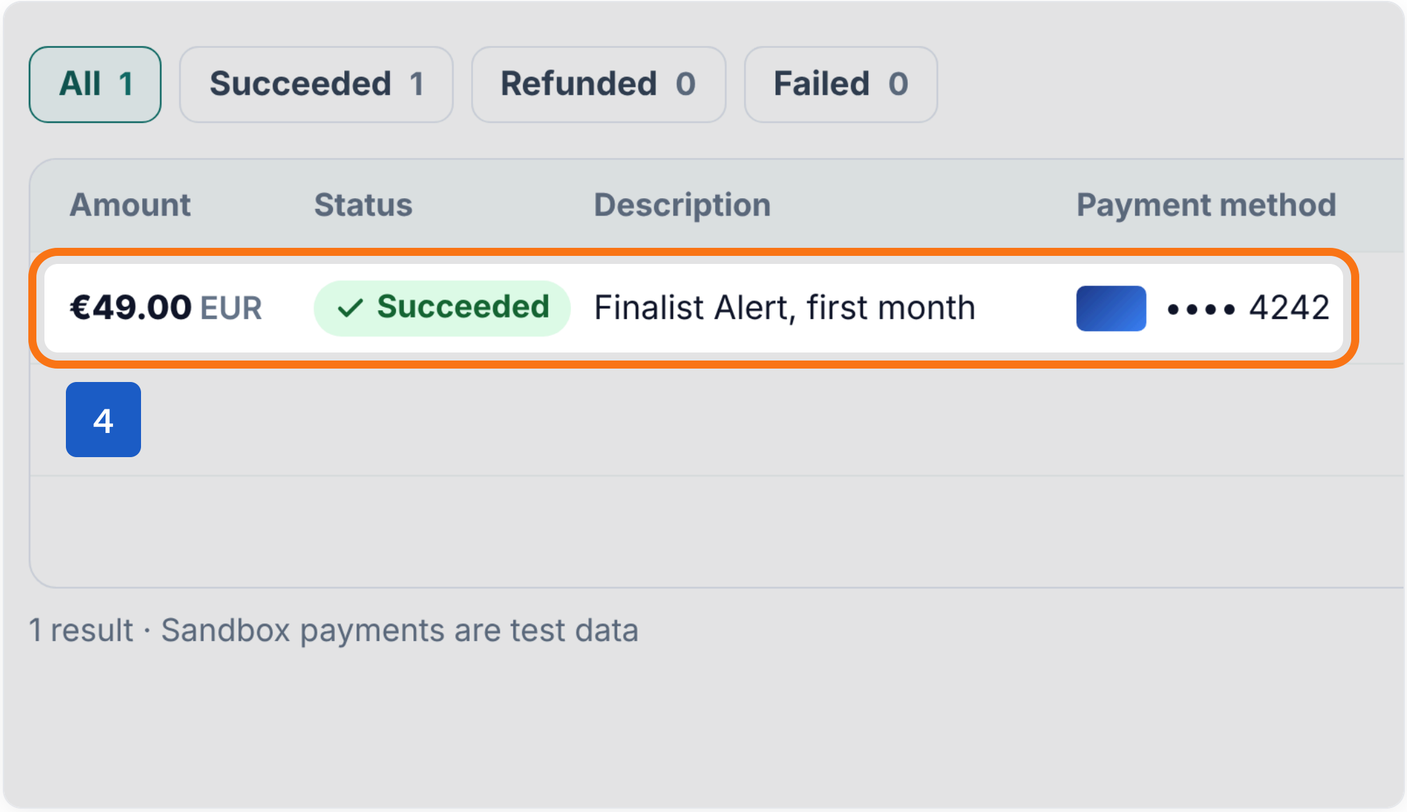
1. Create the product and its price
2. Create the link
3. **Send it while you're still talking**
4. See the payment arrive

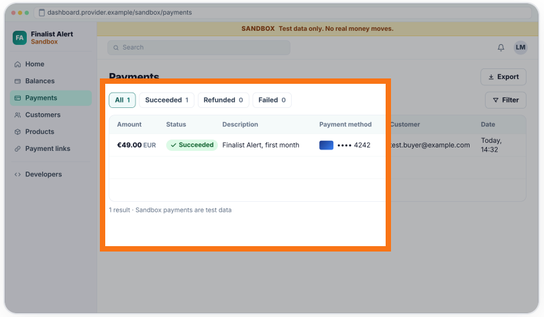
Paste it into the chat. Then stop talking.

ILLUSTRATIVE A payment provider's sandbox, prototyped for this course. Stripe's real screens look different. Steps and button names after docs.stripe.com/payment-links, accessed 2026-10-20, product made up.

LIVE DEMO · STRIPE PAYMENT LINK · SANDBOX

Step 4: See the payment arrive





1. Create the product and its price
2. Create the link
3. Send it while you're still talking
4. **See the payment arrive**

Crop customer data out of your proof.

ILLUSTRATIVE A payment provider's sandbox, prototyped for this course. Stripe's real screens look different. Steps and button names after docs.stripe.com/payment-links, accessed 2026-10-20, product made up.

ASK FOR MONEY TODAY

B2B often pays by invoice. Number it from 001

Paid, a numbered invoice counts like a link

Finalist Alert GbR · Musterstraße 1 · 80333 München

Made up

Agentur Beispiel GmbH
Beispielweg 2
10115 Berlin

Invoice

Invoice no. 001
Invoice date 16.11.2026

DESCRIPTION	QTY	PRICE	AMOUNT
Finalist Alert, first month, set up by hand for two recruiters	1	€49.00	€49.00
Total			**€49.00**

Steuerbefreiung für Kleinunternehmer nach § 19 UStG.
Please transfer within 14 days to the team account, IBAN DE00 0000 0000 0000 0000 00, reference 001.

The number makes it proof. Count from 001.

Bigger B2B deals add two things: a signed contract, and the ink is dry.

ASK FOR MONEY TODAY

Log every no, word for word

Heard three times? Change the offer or the product

Student Toolkit · team TurbineTrack · shared with 3 founders

P12 *fx* "Can it work offline?" (third time asked)

	A	C	P	Q
4	**Date**	**Role**	**Objection, word for word**	**Objection category**
5	28.04	Owner, 6 techs	"€400 for software we might not keep? I pay per use, not upfront."	price structure
6	28.04	Ops lead, 15 techs	"Who types the old reports in? We have 4 years of Excel."	migration
7	29.04	Owner, 9 techs	"My techs are 55 and hate apps."	adoption
8	02.05	Owner, 12 techs	"If TÜV audits us, is your report format accepted?"	compliance
9	02.05	Ops lead, 8 techs	"Send an invoice and I'll get it approved — don't make me use PayPal."	payment rails
10	05.05	Owner, 6 techs	"€400 is fine. My problem: what happens to our data if you're gone in a year?"	trust/continuity
11	06.05	Owner, 20 techs	"Per-tech pricing punishes me for growing."	price structure
12	07.05	Ops lead, 11 techs	"Can it work offline?" (third time asked)	product/constraint
13	08.05	Owner, 7 techs	"Not before the summer maintenance peak ends."	timing
14	09.05	Owner, 14 techs	"Your demo shows wind. We do wind AND solar."	scope creep

Note · heard 3 times
Markus in an interview, a question in a demo, now here. Into the build.

Interview Log | Use Log | **Pipeline** | Revenue Ladder | Kill Criteria Log

ILLUSTRATIVE Objection Log exemplar, team TurbineTrack, synthetic, in the course resources. Sheet prototyped for this course.

ASK FOR MONEY TODAY

Count only payments from outside your social graph

Any amount counts. Friends' money never does



NOW YOU · PAIRS IN YOUR TEAM · 2 MINUTES

Say your price sentence out loud

Write What they get, the price, the next step today

Say It to your co-founder

Stop Talking after the price

2:00

OUTPUT

Your price sentence

INPUT 4 OF 4 · CHARGE FOR IT · THE ANSWERS

Charge for it: name the price, then stay quiet

1

Why ask for money now?

Customers pay, everyone else is a fan. "I'd pay for that" is no payment

2

How do you ask?

Today, at your offer's price: name it, send the link, stay quiet

3

What counts as a payment?

Any amount from outside your social graph. A paid, numbered invoice counts too

CHAPTER 7 OF 9

Wrap-up and check-out

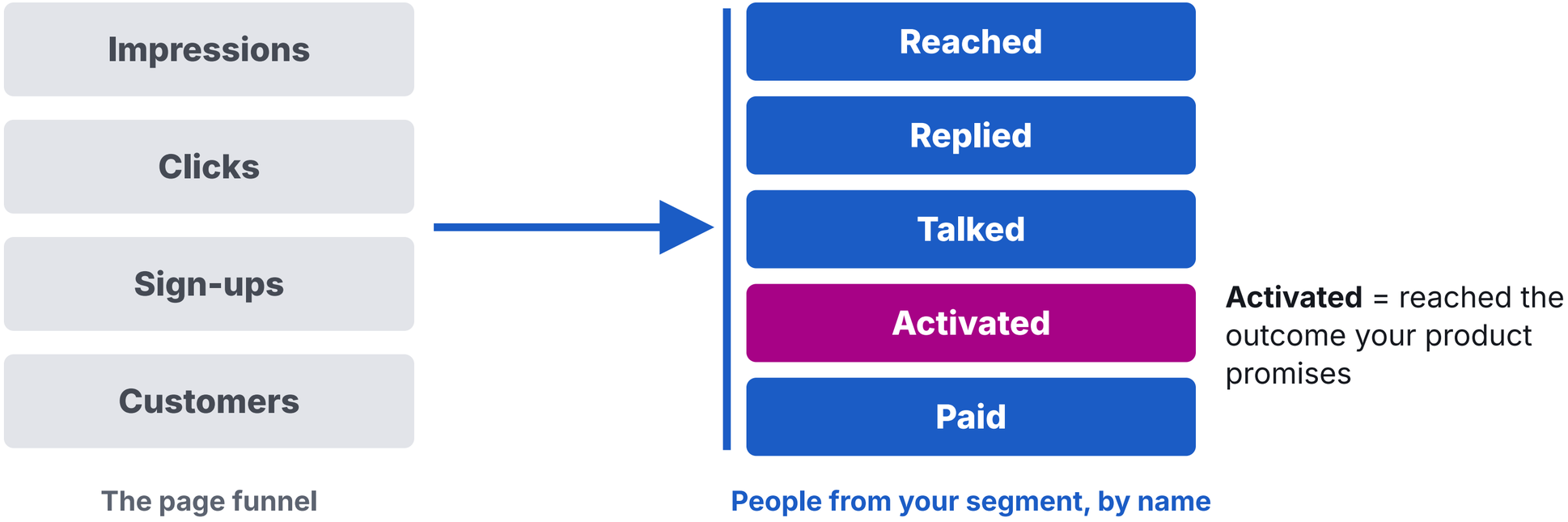
Two pictures to keep, three questions to reflect on, and your week.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Do it by hand: things that don't scale~~
04 ~~Sell it: like a founder~~
05 ~~Count it: make the numbers go brrr~~
06 ~~Charge for it: ask for money today~~
07 **Wrap-up and check-out**
08 Workshop: Sell by hand
09 Case discussion

RECAP · TODAY

Be their concierge, then count people up to paid

Per channel, not page views

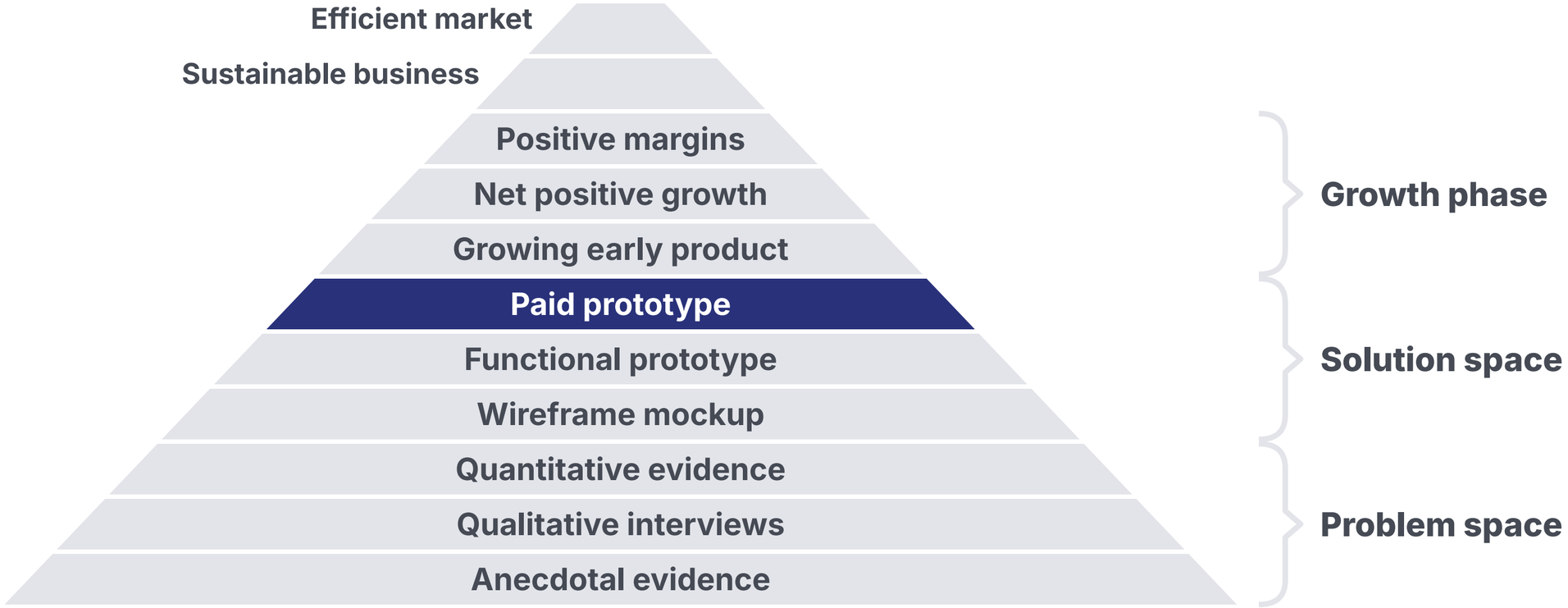


The page funnel

People from your segment, by name

RECAP · RUNG SIX

From today you climb to the wallet



REFLECTION 1 OF 3 · THE CONTENT

What could you apply?



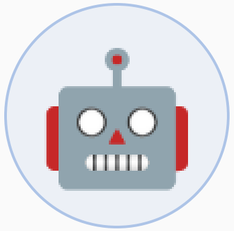
What could you apply?



What gave you a hard time?

REFLECTION 2 OF 3 · THE PROCESS

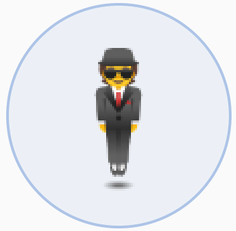
Man vs. machine



Where did AI actually help you?



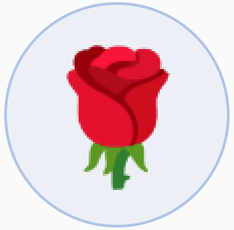
Where was your genius needed?



What are your best hacks to share?

REFLECTION 3 OF 3 · THE RESULTS

Rose, thorn, bud



What was the breakthrough today?



What was the hardest part today?



What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?

HOMEWORK UNTIL NEXT TIME

Ask named people from your segment to pay for your offer at its price, and win 3 paying users from outside your social graph, shown in your payment dashboard or on a numbered invoice.

3 paying users

The learning floor is your first € from outside your social graph.

"If none of the first 10 people from our segment we ask to pay says yes by [midweek date], we change the offer or the segment before the next ask. No yes from fewer than 10 asks crosses it too." Logged before the first ask, counted across the team.

HOMEWORK · HOW TO DO IT

Set up payment first. Then ask and follow up

1. **Set up a way to get paid** first, a team payment link (Team Stack, section 2) or an invoice from 001 (Legal Basics, section 4).

2. **Start in your records,** The ten from The kill decision (M07) first. Ask every buyer and every no for names. Then your segment's groups, found by AI research.

4. **Get them on a call.** Listen 80% of the time. Record only with consent.

5. **Ask for the money there,** at your price. Send the link while you talk.

   Watch out. "Would you pay?" is not an ask. A favour discount is not a sale.

6. **Set it up for them on the spot.** Do by hand what the product can't.

7. **Follow up until yes or no.** Date every open thread. Log objections word for word.

HOMEWORK · WHAT YOU COME BACK WITH

Good is paid by strangers

	GOOD	WEAK
ASKS	18 recruiters asked on calls, €49	40 cold messages
CUSTOMERS	3 by link, 1 by invoice, all strangers	An aunt paid "to help"
NEXT	Demo users convert, cold LinkedIn doesn't	"Everyone loved it"

ILLUSTRATIVE What you come back with, First users (M08) homework. Made up.

Sources in this deck

Aulet, B. (2013). *Disciplined entrepreneurship: 24 steps to a successful startup*. Wiley. Decision-making unit as summarised on d-eship.com.

Covey, S. R. (1989). *The 7 habits of highly effective people*. Free Press. Habit 5, franklincovey.com.

Fisher, R., & Ury, W. (1981). *Getting to yes: Negotiating agreement without giving in*. Houghton Mifflin.

Graham, P. (2013, July). *Do things that don't scale*. paulgraham.com/ds.html

Kolysh, M. (2026, June 22). *How to get your first 10 customers* [Video]. Y Combinator, YC Startup Library.

Murphy, J. J., Allen, P. G., Stevens, T. H., & Weatherhead, D. (2005). A meta-analysis of hypothetical bias in stated preference valuation. *Environmental and Resource Economics, 30*(3), 313–325.

Sources in this deck

Shampanier, K., Mazar, N., & Ariely, D. (2007). Zero as a special price: The true value of free products. *Marketing Science, 26*(6), 742–757.

Stripe. (2026). *Payment Links* and *Testing* documentation. docs.stripe.com, accessed 20 October 2026.

Unbounce. (2024). *Conversion benchmark report: SaaS*. unbounce.com/conversion-benchmark-report/saas-conversion-rate/

Weger, H., Castle Bell, G., Minei, E. M., & Robinson, M. C. (2014). The relative effectiveness of active listening in initial interactions. *International Journal of Listening, 28*(1), 13–31.

Course resources: Glossary, Grading Rubric, Team Stack (section 2), Legal Basics (section 4), Objection Log exemplar, frameworks 01, 02, 03 and 06.

Go sell. See you with your first customers!

MODULE 08 · FINDING FIRST USERS · WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

Workshop: Sell by hand

Who are your first ten customers — by name?

COURSE PATH



MODULE 08 · WORKSHOP

Workshop: Sell by hand

Real people, real asks, real money, with a founder in every conversation.

01 Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship
02 Your presentations
03 **Do it by hand: things that don't scale**
04 **Sell it: like a founder**
05 **Count it: make the numbers go brrr**
06 **Charge for it: ask for money today**
07 Wrap-up and check-out
08 **Workshop: Sell by hand**
09 Case discussion

WORKSHOP · STEP 1 OF 3

Name your ten, write the ask

1 STEP 1 · 25 MIN

NAME YOUR TEN, WRITE THE ASK

Ten people who pass all four, a message each

→ Confirm your verdict, offer and price
→ Pull names from your records, the ten from The kill decision (M07) first
→ Keep those who pass all four filters
→ Log the line, dated with your midweek day, first
→ Write in their words. Quote, offer, price, one next step

Output Ten names and messages, a dated line **Minutes** 25

GOOD

"Lena, you lose a finalist a month. We set it up in 20 minutes, €49 a month. Call at 10?"

WEAK

"We're revolutionizing recruiting with AI. See our website!"

25:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 2 OF 3

Ask live, set it up

2 STEP 2 · 40 MIN

ASK LIVE, SET IT UP

Every yes turned into use before the call ends

- → Rehearse with a co-founder or an AI, labelled as prep
- → Call whoever said yes to a demo, then message
- → Ask for the money at your price, then stay quiet
- → Set it up on a shared screen, send the link
- → Log every answer, objections word for word

Output Asks made, answers and objections logged

Minutes 40

GOOD

Six asked, two calls, Lena paid €49 by link. Her objection, "Who types in our candidates?"

WEAK

Ten LinkedIn messages with a link. "We'll see."

40:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 3 OF 3

Count, then commit

3 STEP 3 · 25 MIN

COUNT, THEN COMMIT

Find the drop. Commit the week

→ Draw your funnel per channel, reached to paid
→ Pick the channel that brings activated users
→ Date every follow-up, never drop the thread
→ Copy the bar, each founder names an ask count

Output A funnel per channel, follow-ups, targets

Minutes 25

GOOD

Demo users, 6 reached, 2 talked, 1 activated, 1 paid. Cold LinkedIn, 4 reached, 0 replies. Double down on demo users.

WEAK

"1,200 impressions on our post!"

25:00

WORKSHOP · DURING STEP 1

Arrived empty-handed?

No offer or names? Price a concierge offer, what you'd do by hand for one person. Name ten from your interviews and your segment's groups. Ask.

HOMEWORK UNTIL NEXT TIME

Ask named people from your segment to pay for your offer at its price, and win 3 paying users from outside your social graph, shown in your payment dashboard or on a numbered invoice.

3 paying users

The learning floor is your first € from outside your social graph.

"If none of the first 10 people from our segment we ask to pay says yes by [midweek date], we change the offer or the segment before the next ask. No yes from fewer than 10 asks crosses it too." Logged before the first ask, counted across the team.

Go sell. See you with your first customers!

MODULE 08 · FINDING FIRST USERS · CASE DISCUSSION · ABOUT 90 MINUTES

Case discussion

Who are your first ten customers — by name?

COURSE PATH



MODULE 08 · CASE DISCUSSION

Tacto: The First Customers

Late September 2020 in Munich, with funding, a website and no customer on record.

01 Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship

02 Your presentations

03 **Do it by hand: things that don't scale**

04 **Sell it: like a founder**

05 **Count it: make the numbers go brrr**

06 **Charge for it: ask for money today**

07 Wrap-up and check-out

08 Workshop: Sell by hand

09 **Case discussion**

VOTE 1 · HANDS OR POLL

What should Tacto ask its first customers for?

A Time and feedback in a partnership

B Money from the first conversation, at a price the founders name

2:00

CASE · TIMELINE

From a start in early 2020 to a website with no customer

DATE	EVENT
Early 2020	The founders start and talk with a wide range of Mittelstand firms, by Petry's account of 2023
16 July 2020	Entered in the commercial register as Tactum Technology GmbH, share capital €25,002
Mid-2020	First financing round, by Petry's account of 2023
22 August 2020	Name Tacto Technology GmbH, share capital €30,165
7 September 2020	deutsche-startups.de reports the investment by Visionaries Club and UVC Partners, amount not disclosed
23 September 2020	First archived capture of tacto.ai, no product, no price, no customer on the site

Case Tacto: The First Customers. Exhibit 1, shortened, with two lines from the case text. The "by Petry's account" rows are his recollections of 2023.

CASE · EXHIBIT 2

What tacto.ai showed on 23 September 2020

PAGE	WHAT IT SAID, VERBATIM
Home, promise	"We support procurement teams to focus on what matters by automating what does not."
Home, call to action	"Interested in what we are building? Get in touch via hello@tacto.ai"
About, investors	Visionaries Club, "a Berlin-based early stage VC fund backed by leading European digital founders and family business entrepreneurs". UVC Partners, offering "strategic and operational support, as well as access to a vast network of corporate partners, experienced industry experts and international follow-on investors"
About, business angels	"Hanno Renner (Co-Founder Personio), Johannes Reck (Co-Founder GetYourGuide), Torsten Reil (Co-Founder NaturalMotion), and Michael Wax (Co-Founder Forto)"
Not on the site	Product screens, a price, customers, partners

Source: tacto.ai, home page, About page and imprint, Internet Archive captures of 23 September 2020, see the case's notes. Extracted by the case writer, links and e-mail addresses of individuals left out. Case Tacto: The First Customers.

CASE · BOARD PLAN

Whom first, and what does a yes prove?

Votes · A __ · B __

Our records	Investors' introductions	Strangers in the segment	What a yes proves

VOTE 2 · HANDS OR POLL

Same question. Who moved?

A Time and feedback in a partnership

B Money from the first conversation, at a price the founders name

2:00

Case Tacto: The First Customers. Vote 2, the same question after the discussion.

Go sell. See you with your first customers!